



Big setback: Germany suffered its first World Cup elimination via a penalty shootout, having won its previous four, and only its second shootout failure at a major tournament after losing the Euro 1976 final. REUTERS

A CRISIS OF IDENTITY

How poor decisions and fading identities sent Germany and Brazil **crashing** out of the World Cup.

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Two teams, nine World Cup titles. Brazil and Germany, unsurprisingly, always begin every FIFA World Cup as title challengers. Yet in 2026, both were sent packing by rare guests at the tournament.

Paraguay eliminated Germany on penalties in the Round of 32, and Norway shut the door on Brazil in the Round of 16.

Across the last 22 editions of the tournament, at least one of the two reached the final 14 times, which begs the question: Did Brazil and Germany read the script wrong?

Germany, under young coach Julian Nagelsmann, arrived at the 2026 World Cup with a blend of youth and experience, but his selection raised several questions about consistency.

Manuel Neuer, the only remaining member of the 2014 squad, returned as Germany's No. 1 after two years. In doing so, he

replaced Oliver Baumann, whom Nagelsmann had previously backed as his first-choice goalkeeper.

The result: Germany failed to keep a clean sheet for the second consecutive World Cup. Neuer was in goal for both campaigns.

A long domestic season and the injuries that followed did not help Germany's cause.

Serge Gnabry, who would otherwise have been the highest goalscorer in Germany's 2026 squad, missed the tournament because of a thigh injury. Nico Schlotterbeck then injured his ankle during the World Cup, leaving Germany scrambling for alternatives against Paraguay.

Selection also proved costly. Starting Deniz Undav, a striker, ahead of Jamal Musiala, an attacking midfielder, altered the team's shape midway through the tournament.